severe. First, there is the ‘caloric cost of culture’ whereby migrants end up consuming fewer calories per rupee, because they bring along food preferences from their places of origin and end up paying higher values for them.[13] More importantly, maternal health is affected as migrants often don’t have access to public services that they have back home and migrants avoid paying for health care due to exorbitant costs.[14] This can have an inter-generational impact on the health of children and their cognitive development. These health risks are compounded by the fact that ‘footloose labour’ in informal jobs in the urban sector faces a high degree of income volatility and a very real prospect of downward mobility.[15] Nevertheless, the idea that urban poverty is an extension of rural poverty is incorrect and, on most dimensions, the average slum-dweller in India is better off than counterparts of the same social group in villages.[16]

The relationship between spatial and economic mobility in India is highly contingent on the nature of migration by duration. In short-term seasonal migration streams dominated by the poorer segments of the Indian population towards harvesting operations and construction work, remittances are scarce, savings are limited, debts are high and the economic returns of migration are low. According to Priya Deshingkar, a pioneering researcher on Indian migration, these migrations are for survival or ‘coping’ mechanisms, whereas semi-permanent circular migrations through social networks are instances of ‘accumulative’ migration.[17] Based on extensive field work across many parts of India, her research showed that on balance, migration was an important route out of poverty through livelihood diversification. The historical evidence of the Great Indian Migration Wave also points to a similar conclusion and shows a clear pattern where ‘coping’ types of migration transformed into ‘accumulative’ migrations in the long run.

The selective nature of migration for work in India affects not only poverty, but also inequality. International remittances are directed to the relatively more developed states, contributing to widening inter-state inequalities. Remittances are also sent primarily by semi-permanent and permanent migrants, who are drawn from the relatively richer segments of